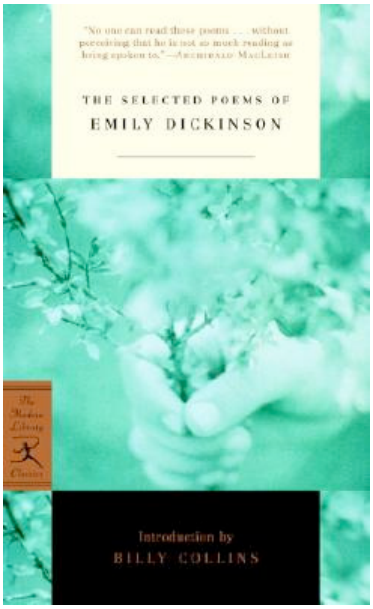
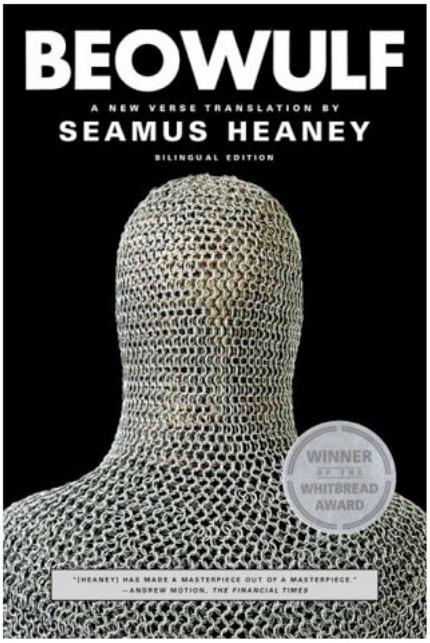
UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

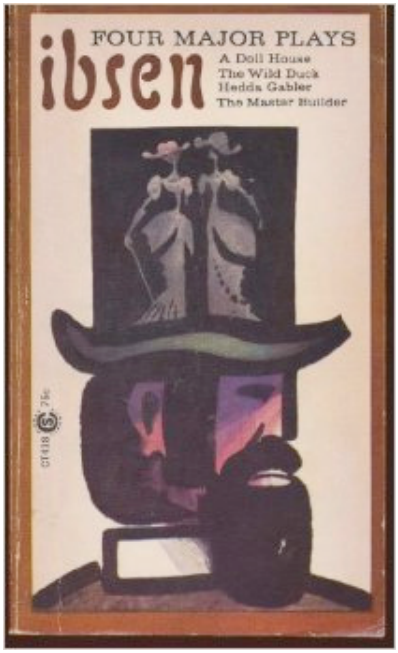
Making a World of Difference

Literary Criticism

Regional • 2015







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University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest • Region • 2015

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. [redacted]

2. The system for describing conventional rhythms by dividing lines into feet, indicating the locations of binomial accents, and counting the syllables is known as

   A) exegesis.
   B) reception theory.
   C) scansion.
   D) typology.
   E) versification.

3. The final unraveling of a plot, the solution of a mystery, or an explanation or outcome is known as (the)

   A) *débat*.
   B) *de casibus*.
   C) *dénouement*.
   D) *deus ex machina*.
   E) *dolce stil nuovo*.

4. The eighteenth-century English author of *The Shortest Way with Dissenters*, *The Review*, *Robinson Crusoe*, *The Journal of the Plague Year*, and *Moll Flanders* is

   A) Jane Austen.
   B) Daniel Defoe.
   C) Oliver Goldsmith.
   D) Laurence Sterne.
   E) Jonathan Swift.

5. **Not** one of the commonly used feet in English-language poetic expression is the

   A) anapest.
   B) dactyl.
   C) iamb.
   D) paeon.
   E) trochee.

6. The group of eighteenth-century English poets who wrote poems on death and immortality that attempt to establish an atmosphere of pleasing gloom in order to call up the horrors of death through the imagery of the charnel house and similar places is the

   A) Graveyard School.
   B) Kailyard School.
   C) Lake School.
   D) Satanic School.
   E) Spasmodic School.

7. The fictional author of a work supposedly written by someone other than the actual author is known as a(n)

   A) allonym.
   B) nom de plume.
   C) pseudonym.
   D) putative author.
   E) *redende name*.

8. A poem expressing grief in a very intense and personal manner is a(n)

   A) aubade.
   B) epithalamium.
   C) lament.
   D) ode.
   E) pastoral.

9. The name given in derision to a group of nineteenth-century English novelists whose writing emphasizes gentility and etiquette is the

   A) School of Night.
   B) Silver-Fork School.
   C) Transcendental Club.
   D) Tribe of Ben.
   E) University Wits.

10. A self-contradictory combination of words or smaller verbal units is a(n)

    A) hyperbole.
    B) litotes.
    C) mimesis.
    D) oxymoron.
    E) paradox.

11. The gathering of writers and thinkers, many of whom lived in a residential district near central London, after which the group takes its name, and counting among its membership Virginia Woolf, Lytton Strachey, E. M. Forster, and John Maynard Keynes, among others, is the

A) Bloomsbury Group.
B) Bluestockings.
C) Fugitives.
D) Knickerbocker Group.
E) Scriblerus Club.

12. The recipient of the 2001 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction for his *Amazing Adventures of Kavalier and Cla*y is

A) Michael Chabon.
B) William Faulkner.
C) William Kennedy.
D) Harper Lee.
E) James A. Michener.

13. The author of the onomatopoeic poem "The Skater of Ghost Lake" and recipient of the 1942 Pulitzer Prize for Poetry for his autobiographical collection entitled *The Dust Which Is God* is

A) W. H. Auden.
B) Stephen Vincent Benét.
C) William Rose Benét.
D) Edwin Arlington Robinson.
E) Mark Van Doren.

14. The process by which an unhealthy emotional state produced by an imbalance of feelings is corrected and emotional health is restored, especially in terms of an audience's response to the fate of a tragic hero, is known as

A) aporia.
B) catharsis.
C) hubris.
D) pleonasm.
E) reification.

15. An interlude in which a drama's actors freeze in position and then resume action as before or hold their positions until the curtain falls is a(n)

A) establishing shot.
B) hiatus.
C) macrosegment.
D) suspension of disbelief.
E) tableau.

16. The name for a group of prizes/awards for journalism, literature, music, biography, history, and other fields awarded since 1917 by the School of Journalism and the Board of Trustees of Columbia University is the

A) Booker Prizes.
B) Nobel Prizes.
C) Orange Prizes.
D) PEN American Center Awards.
E) Pulitzer Prizes.

17. **Not** one of the four ages that comprise the English Renaissance Period (1500-1660) is the

A) Augustan Age.
B) Caroline Age.
C) Early Tudor Age.
D) Elizabethan Age.
E) Jacobean Age.

18. The group of American writers of the 1950s and '60s, including Allen Ginsberg and Jack Kerouac, in rebellion against what they conceived of as the failures of American culture is the

A) Agrarians.
B) Angry Young Men.
C) Beat Generation.
D) Lollards.
E) Muckrakers.

19. The celebrated twentieth-century short story author whose collections *The Worn Path* and *Collected Stories*, as well as her prize-winning novel *The Optimist's Daughter*, earned her national acclaim is

A) Willa Cather.
B) Shirley Ann Grau.
C) Alison Lurie.
D) Joyce Carol Oates.
E) Eudora Welty.

20. The term used metaphorically as a critical standard by Matthew Arnold to detect the presence or absence of high poetic quality is (the)

A) aesthetic distance.
B) alienation effect.
C) jumping the shark.
D) objective correlative.
E) touchstone.

21. The fixed nineteen-line form, originally French, employing only two rhymes and repeating two of the lines according to the pattern abá aba abá aba abá abaá is the

A) cinquain.
B) pantoum.
C) rondeau.
D) *terza rima*.
E) villanelle.

22. The literary group writing during the English Renaissance who favored the introduction of heavy Latin and Greek words into the standard English vocabulary is the

A) Goliards.
B) Inkhornists.
C) Parnassians.
D) Stationers' Company.
E) University Wits.

23. The nineteenth-century American author of the long narrative poem *Snow-Bound* and the collections *In War Time and Other Poems*, *National Lyrics*, and *Among the Hills* is

A) Charles Brockden Brown.
B) James Fenimore Cooper.
C) Ralph Waldo Emerson.
D) Edgar Allan Poe.
E) John Greenleaf Whittier.

24. The American playwright who adapted Arthur Koestler's *Darkness at Noon* for the stage and who received the 1934 Pulitzer Prize for Drama for *Men in White* is

A) Frank D. Gilroy.
B) Sidney Kingsley.
C) Eugene O'Neill.
D) Will Smith.
E) Thornton Wilder.

25. The term that is widely used to refer to a "second self" created by an author and through whom, in the case of prose, the narrative is told is

A) allonym.
B) eponym.
C) persona.
D) pseudonym.
E) putative author.

26. The twentieth-century Russian writer, author of *One Day in the Life of Ivan Denisovich*, *Cancer Ward*, and *The Gulag Archipelago*, who was awarded the 1970 Nobel Prize for Literature is

A) Ivan A. Bunin.
B) Boris L. Pasternak.
C) Mikhail A. Sholokhov.
D) Alexander I. Solzhenitsyn.
E) Leo N. Tolstoy.

27. An outgrowth of an earlier group and associated with the Irish Literary Revival, a group founded by William Butler Yeats and Lady Gregory in 1899, enduring until 1951, is the

A) Abbey Theatre.
B) Fleshly School.
C) Gaelic Movement.
D) Lost Generation.
E) Pre-Raphaelites.

28. An important genre in the vernacular literatures of Western Europe, including Old English (of which it is the most secular of the extant genres), a genre requiring interpretation, is the

A) art epic.
B) folk epic.
C) hymn.
D) riddle.
E) saga.

29. **Not** among the very influential twentieth-century mythopoeic Irish novelist, playwright, and poet James Joyce's literary works is

A) *Dracula.*
B) *Dubliners.*
C) *Finnegans Wake.*
D) *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man.*
E) *Ulysses.*

30. The conventionalized stanza appearing at the close of certain kinds of poems frequently serving as a "sending" or "dispatching" poem is a(n)

A) addendum.
B) coda.
C) envoy.
D) peroration.
E) versicle.

Part 2: The UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

Items 31-36 are associated with Henrik Ibsen's *A Doll House*.
Items 37-42 are associated with Seamus Heaney's translation of *Beowulf*.
Items 43-50 are associated with Emily Dickinson's poetry (selected).

31. In Henrik Ibsen's *A Doll House* the confidence shared in the statement, "So many times I've felt you'd almost rather be with me than with Helmer," is shared by

A) Nils with Kristine.
B) Nils with Nora.
C) Rank with Kristine.
D) Rank with Nora.
E) Torvald with Nora.

32. Helmer's chastising comment, "A songbird needs a clean beak to warble with," is in response to Nora's having

A) bitten her lip while dancing the tarantella.
B) failed to admit Krogstad had visited.
C) lied about the forging of the signature.
D) macaroon crumbs on her lips.
E) pricked her lip with a sewing needle.

33. The tone of her cryptic remark in Act 1, "Hm, if you only knew what expenses we larks and squirrels have," is, given the history that haunts an uneasy Nora,

A) angrily resentful.
B) bizarrely malicious.
C) cautiously facetious.
D) deeply sarcastic.
E) painfully scornful.

34. Crucial to the play's crisis is the declaration, "But there's no one who gives up honor for love," a disturbing precept uttered by

A) Anne-Marie.
B) Nils.
C) Nora.
D) Rank.
E) Torvald.

35. The accusatory remark, "He with his suffering and loneliness—like a dark cloud setting off our sunlit happiness," is

A) Helmer's description of Krogstad.
B) Helmer's description of Rank.
C) Nora's description of Krogstad.
D) Nora's description of Torvald.
E) Rank's description of Torvald.

36. "Helmer's got to learn everything; this dreadful secret has to be aired; those two have to come to a full understanding; all these lies and evasions can't go on" is a strong opinion voiced by

A) Helmer.
B) Krogstad.
C) Linde.
D) Nora's father's spirit.
E) Rank.

37. In Heaney's translation of *Beowulf* the length of time that Grendel's rampage has lasted—"twelve winters"—is laden with

A) ambiguity.
B) connotation.
C) denotation.
D) isobaric stress.
E) paradox.

38. The scop's philosophical comment, "Whoever remains / for long here in this earthly life / will enjoy and endure more than enough," suggests a(n)

A) elegiac attitude.
B) gift for versification.
C) hyperbolic understanding.
D) predisposition for euphemism.
E) recantation of all things heroic.

39. "Unferth [. . .], / could hardly have remembered the ranting speech / he had made in his cups." The "ranting speech" to which the scop refers is (a)

A) bombast.
B) flyting.
C) gasconade.
D) rodomontade.
E) stichomythia.

40. Unferth's lending to Beowulf the sword Hrunting is described by Heaney as being of "no small importance," is a fine example of

A) ambiguity.
B) equivoque.
C) litotes.
D) meiosis.
E) understatement.

41. The "rune-markings correctly incised" on the sword given to Hrothgar are

A) claw marks from combating Grendel.
B) gauge marks for measuring the length of battle scars.
C) scoring from the dragon's teeth.
D) tick marks indicating the number of dragons slain.
E) words in a Germanic alphabet.

42. The only treasure that Beowulf carries away from the fight with Grendel's mother is a/the

A) battled-scarred linden shield.
B) gold mead cup stolen from Heorot.
C) hilt of the dagger Grendel carried.
D) melted sword from the days of the giants.
E) pouch of silver boar's head-embossed coins.

Items 43-46 refer to Emily Dickinson's

[A narrow fellow in the grass]

A narrow fellow in the grass
Occasionally rides;
You may have met him,—did you not?
His notice sudden is.

The grass divides as with a comb,
A spotted shaft is seen;
And then it closes at your feet
And opens further on.

He likes a boggy acre,
A floor too cool for corn.
Yet when a child, and barefoot,
I more than once, at morn,

Have passed, I thought, a whip-lash
Unbraiding in the sun,—
When, stooping to secure it,
It wrinkled, and was gone.

Several of nature's people
I know, and they know me;
I feel for them a transport
Of cordiality;

But never met this fellow,
Attended or alone,
Without a tighter breathing,
And zero at the bone.

43. The imagery of Dickinson's poem is primarily

A) auditory.
B) gustatory.
C) olfactory.
D) tactile.
E) visual.

44. The auditory imagery of line 4 relies particularly on

A) assonance.
B) consonance.
C) dissonance.
D) feminine endings.
E) sigmatism.

45. The poem's final line speaks to a(n)

A) cryobiologist's epiphany.
B) emotional intensity.
C) herpetologist's ecstasy.
D) remembered encounter with another snake.
E) sudden change in weather conditions.

46. Dickinson's poem can be recognized as a(n)

A) ballad.
B) doggerel.
C) ode.
D) riddle.
E) Skeltonic verse.

Items 47-50 refer to Emily Dickinson's

[One dignity delays for all]

One dignity delays for all,
One mitred afternoon
None can avoid this purple,
None evade this crown.

Coach it insures, and footmen,
Chamber and state and throng;
Bells, also, in the village,
As we ride grand along.

What dignified attendants!
What service when we pause!
How loyally at parting
Their hundred hats they raise!

Her pomp surpassing ermine,
When simple you and I
Present our meek escutcheon,
And claim the rank to die!

47. The subject of Dickinson's "[One dignity]" is

A) ceremony.
B) death.
C) dignity.
D) loyalty.
E) royalty.

48. The words *mitred* (line 2) and, especially, *ermine* (line 13) are examples of

A) conceit.
B) heaping figure.
C) kenning.
D) metonymy.
E) synæsthesia.

49. Line 5's "Coach it insures, and footmen" refers to a

A) bishop's carriage.
B) hearse.
C) royal couple's carriage.
D) sedan chair.
E) soccer instructor.

50. Line 15's phrase "meek escutcheon," while both metaphorical and metonymic, is, ultimately

A) allusive.
B) hyperbolic.
C) oxymoronic.
D) paradoxical.
E) rhopalic.

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism
15 items (2 points each)

Items 51-57 refer to Gwen Harwood's

In the Park

She sits in the park. Her clothes are out of date.
Two children whine and bicker, tug her skirt.
A third draws aimless patterns in the dirt
Someone she loved once passes by—too late

to feign* indifference to that casual nod. *pretend
"How nice," et cetera. "Time holds great surprises."
From his neat head unquestionably rises
a small balloon . . . "but for the grace of God . . ."

They stand a while in flickering light, rehearsing
the children's names and birthdays. "It's so sweet
to hear their chatter, watch them grow and thrive,"
she says to his departing smile. Then, nursing
the youngest child, sits staring at her feet.
To the Wind she says, "They have eaten me alive."

51. Gwen Harwood's "In the Park" is most like a(n)

A) English sonnet.
B) Italian sonnet.
C) Miltonic stanza.
D) Pushkin stanza.
E) Spenserian sonnet.

52. The "small balloon" (line 8) suggests a graphic convention that is used to indicate a person's

A) lost idea.
B) moment of absolute nexility.
C) remembering a birthday party.
D) rushing gait.
E) thought.

53. Lines 9 and 12 end with

A) feminine rhyme.
B) head rhyme.
C) masculine rhyme.
D) *rime riche*.
E) slant rhyme.

54. The imagery of the children in the park is reinforced in lines 2 and 11 by

A) hypallage.
B) melopoeia.
C) mythopoeia.
D) onomatopoeia.
E) sigmatism.

55. The continuation of both the poem's sense and the grammatical construction from the first quatrain to the second quatrain is called

A) boustrophedon.
B) enjambment.
C) metathesis.
D) tagline.
E) truncation.

56. The sonnet ends with the speaker saying that "[t]hey have eaten [her] alive"; at this point the speaker is sharing a(n)

A) epiphany.
B) foul copy.
C) genteel tradition.
D) harangue.
E) inscape.

57. Unconventionally, the volta in Harwood's sonnet occurs in

A) line 4.
B) line 8.
C) line 9.
D) line 12.
E) line 14.

Items 58-62 refer to W. H. Auden's

Funeral Blues

Stop all the clocks, cut off the telephone,
Prevent the dog from barking with a juicy bone,
Silence the pianos and with muffled drum
Bring out the coffin, let the mourners come.

Let aeroplanes circle moaning overhead
Scribbling on the sky the message He Is Dead,
Put crêpe bows round the white necks of the public doves,
Let the traffic policemen wear black cotton gloves.

He was my North, my South, my East and West,
My working week and my Sunday rest,
My noon, my midnight, my talk, my song;
I thought that love would last for ever: I was wrong.

The stars are not wanted now: put out every one;
Pack up the moon and dismantle the sun;
Pour away the ocean and sweep up the wood;
For nothing now can ever come to any good.

58. The contrast that is initiated in the first stanza of W. H. Auden's "Funeral Blues" and which finds its opposite in the last stanza is a move from the

A) mechanical to the spiritual.
B) mournful to the celebratory.
C) musical to the directional.
D) noisy to the peaceful.
E) particular to the universal.

59. The speaker's delivery of commands to what seems to be the world in general should be recognized as

A) apostrophe.
B) harangue.
C) reification.
D) rhetorical accent.
E) synæthesia.

60. In the third stanza of "Funeral Blues" the speaker offers a series of

A) elisions.
B) heteronyms.
C) metaphors.
D) paradoxes.
E) similes.

61. In spite of its tendency toward rage, the type of formal poem represented by Auden's "Funeral Blues" is

A) bucolic.
B) elegy.
C) eulogy.
D) madrigal.
E) pastoral.

62. The third stanza's declarations are

A) ambiguous.
B) hyperbolic.
C) literal.
D) macabre.
E) repetitive.

Items 63-65 refer to Gerard Manley Hopkins's

Pied Beauty

Glory be to God for dappled things—
For skies of couple-colour as a brinded cow;
For rose-moles all in stipple upon trout that swim;
Fresh-firecoal chestnut-falls; finches' wings;
Landscape plotted and pieced—fold, fallow, and plough;
And áll trádes, their gear and tackle and trim.

All things counter, original, spare, strange;
Whatever is fickle, freckled (who knows how?)
With swift, slow; sweet, sour; adazzle, dim;
He fathers-forth whose beauty is past change:
Praise him.

63. The sequence in line 9 of Hopkins's second stanza consists of

A) lampooning pairs.
B) malaphoristic pairs.
C) neologistic pairs.
D) oxymoronic pairs.
E) paradoxical pairs.

64. The overriding melopoeic quality of Hopkins's sonnet depends on

A) alliteration.
B) heteroglossia.
C) nonce words.
D) onomatopoeia.
E) sigmatism.

Item 65 is on the next page.

65. The form of Hopkins's "Pied Beauty" is the

A) Anglo-Italian sonnet.
B) caudate sonnet.
C) curtal sonnet.
D) English sonnet.
E) Italian sonnet.

Required tie-breaking essay prompt immediately below.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay (required)

Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie. Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.

Three sheets of paper have been provided; your written response should reflect the *Handbook*'s notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than just a few sentences.

Read Philip Levine's "Gospel," and, focusing on the poem's sensory imagery, offer a discussion of the speaker's thematic "How weightless / words are when nothing will do."

Gospel*

The new grass rising in the hills,
the cows loitering in the morning chill,
a dozen or more old browns hidden
in the shadows of the cottonwoods
beside the streambed. I go higher
to where the road gives up and there's
only a faint path strewn with lupine*
between the mountain oaks. I don't
ask myself what I'm looking for.
I didn't come for answers
to a place like this, I came to walk
on the earth, still cold, still silent.
Still ungiving, I've said to myself,
although it greets me with last year's
dead thistles and this year's
hard spines, early blooming
wild onions, the curling remains
of spider's cloth. What did I bring
to the dance? In my back pocket
a crushed letter from a woman
I've never met bearing bad news
I can do nothing about. So I wander
these woods half sightless while
a west wind picks up in the trees
clustered above. The pines make
a music like no other, rising and
falling like a distant surf at night
that calms the darkness before
first light. "Soughing" we call it, from
Old English, no less. How weightless
words are when nothing will do.

Philip Levine (1928 – 2015)

*the literal meaning of gospel is 'good news'

*a type of plant

ANSWER SHEET

UIL Literary Criticism

Items 1-30 **1** *point each*

1. ____
2. ____
3. ____
4. ____
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30. ____

Items 31-65 **2** *points each*

31. ____
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_____
Part 3

_____
contestant number

_____
SCORE

Please note that the objective scores should not be altered to reflect the breaking of any ties.

Simply adjust ranking.

The thirty items in Part 1 are worth one point each.

The twenty items in Part 2 are worth two points each.

The fifteen items in Part 3 are worth two points each.

FIRST GRADER

number correct x 1 _____

\+

number correct x 2 _____

= _____

_____
initials

SECOND GRADER

number correct x 1 _____

\+

number correct x 2 _____

= _____

_____
initials

THIRD GRADER

number correct x 1 _____

\+

number correct x 2 _____

= _____

_____
initials

KEY

UIL Literary Criticism
Region • 2015

line arrows up ➔

1.	■	■
2.	C	430
3.	C	135
4.	B	543
5.	D	205; 346
6.	A	221
7.	D	393
8.	C	268
9.	B	445
10.	D	345
11.	A	61
12.	A	603
13.	C	604
14.	B	77
15.	E	472
16.	E	389
17.	A	173
18.	C	51
19.	E	588
20.	E	479
21.	E	497
22.	B	253
23.	E	563
24.	B	607
25.	C	361
26.	D	600
27.	A	1
28.	D	416
29.	A	573
30.	C	175
31.	D	84
32.	B	68
33.	C	
34.	E	113
35.	B	104
36.	C	97
37.	B	107
38.	A	1059-61
39.	B	1466;201
40.	C	1956;275
41.	E	1695;425
42.	D	1559;1613
43.	E	
44.	E	
45.	B	
46.	D	416
47.	B	
48.	D	298
49.	B	
50.	C	345
51.	B	260
52.	E	
53.	A	196
54.	D	337
55.	B	174
56.	A	178
57.	D	
58.	E	
59.	A	37
60.	C	294
61.	B	167
62.	B	242
63.	D	345
64.	A	13
65.	C	126

FOLD along the **three** longitudinal lines for ease in grading. ➔

Please note that the objective scores should not be altered to reflect the breaking of any ties. ***Simply adjust ranking***.

The thirty items in Part 1 are worth one point each.

The twenty items in Part 2 are worth two points each.

The fifteen items in Part 3 are worth two points each.

DO NOT mark (cross out) actual **LETTER** answer; mark the answer **NUMERAL**.

Page numbers refer to the *Handbook* 12e, to the Signet *House*, to the Norton *Beowulf*, and to Collins's Dickinson collection.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Philip Levine's "Gospel"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of sensory imagery as it contributes to the theme of Philip Levine's "Gospel" include

diction,
imagery,
irony,
metaphor,
rhetorical question,
theme, and
tone.

The young writer's approach to a discussion of the sensory imagery of Levine's "Gospel" might turn on a recognition that imagery controls the tone of the poem and thus supports the isolation and, to some degree, the helplessness that is central to the speaker's experience, a sentiment coloring the speaker's final observation, "How weightless / words are when nothing will do" (lines 30-31).

The student of Anglo-Saxon poetry might sense the poem's thematic and tonal kinship with the elegies of the Anglo-Saxon canon he or she has read this season. That this kinship is somehow the focus of a tie-breaking essay should not make that essay automatically or necessarily a better essay this season. The connection would, indeed, be a happy one; however, the tie-breaking prompt does not point the contestant in that direction.

The contestant might appreciate the positioning of the metaphor that is the question "What did I bring / to the dance?" (lines 18-19). The speaker has wandered through a natural world that reinforces a meditative brooding, and, caught up in the natural imagery of memory (lines 14-18), the speaker dwells on a question regarding his own contribution: "What did I bring / to the dance?" What follows the rhetorical question turns on the immediate and distant crushed letter (line 20) in his pocket.

Something might be made of the poem's title "good news" and the poem's last line, which essentially contradicts or denies the efficacy of words (good news). Perhaps the natural world acts as both reminder of the inefficacy, the inadequacy, of words and solace in the face of this inadequacy, part of the irony being that it is the poem, as a collection of words that work, arguably, toward—through sensory imagery—a calming (line 28) that has been used to explore the inadequacy.